

Ask for lemon or lime wedges to give it a bit of flavor, or bring your own powder packets to quickly turn it into lemonade if you can't stand the plain taste.

The key is to make sodas a rare, but special treat. It will be hard at first, but this simple switch literally pays you dollars in savings. And if you can't give up soda just yet, try splitting a large drink with your family. Just be careful—most establishments frown on getting free refills if you share drinks among family members, as refills should be per person only.

4. SPLIT A MEAL

Food portions these days are HUGE. I usually cut my entree in half immediately after receiving it, then take leftovers home for tomorrow's lunch. I've also thrown in a few extra rolls that were left over from the dinner table too, but that might be a result of my carb addiction. Either way, I figure if I'm spending that kind of money on food, I better savor each bite and make it last!

Also consider splitting a meal between two, even three people to get more mileage out of the final bill. If an entree doesn't look big enough, you may want to order an appetizer as well to be sure you have enough. These are often less expensive than regular dinners, and fill your stomach before the main course.

For fast food chains, order a big carton of fries and share among family members for even more savings. It's much cheaper than individual packs, and lets parents determine their kids' serving sizes beforehand.

READER TIP:

From the very beginning, our daughter eats what we eat (aside from baby food). We do not buy kids' meals at restaurants. She's only 2.5 so she never eats more than a few bites anyway; she just shares whatever I'm eating. That saves at least \$5 every time!

—Jennifer, MI